

American Intonation: A Working Guide

Read Part 1 once. Then live in Part 2 — it's the actual work, in order. Part 3 is reference; don't read it, consult it.

PART 1 — WHAT'S ACTUALLY WRONG

The notation (four things, that's all)

Symbol	Means
CAPS	the strong syllable — long, clear, loud
ə	schwa: the lazy “uh”. Short, vague, lips relaxed.
˘ ˙	pitch falls / rises, starting on the CAPS syllable
\\	a boundary — end of one chunk of thought

So də-VEL-əp-mənt means: mush, **strong**, mush, mush.

Nothing else. If you see IPA anywhere in this document, I've made a mistake.

Why you have an accent

English has no gaps between words. So how does an American find where one word ends and the next begins?

They guess. The guess is: **a strong syllable means a new word is starting**. It works because most English words begin strong.

Now say development the French way — four clear syllables of roughly equal length. To their ear, that's four word-starts. Their shortcut returns nonsense and they fall back on slow, effortful parsing.

That is your accent. Not your R, not your TH. You are handing your listener four words where you meant one.

Which gives you the single most important sentence in this guide:

English stress is not something you add to a syllable. It's a contrast you create by destroying the syllables around it.

You already push on the right syllable sometimes. You never destroy the neighbours. That's the whole job.

The second problem

French puts its emphasis at the **end of a phrase**. English puts it on a **specific syllable inside a specific word**, usually in the middle.

You have plenty of melody. It's just glued to the wrong place. That's what people mean by "French sing-song" — the tune is fine, the anchor points are wrong.

Two problems. Everything below fixes one or the other.

One sentence, five layers

Here's the whole system on a single sentence. Say each version out loud before reading the next.

I think the development team's estimate is probably a bit optimistic.

Layer 0 — what you probably do now

I THINK | the DÉ-VE-LOP-MENT TEAM'S ES-TI-MATE | is PRO-BA-BLY a BIT OP-TI-MIS-TIC ↗

Every syllable full and roughly equal. A rise at the end of each chunk. Twenty-two audible beats where an American gives six.

Layer 1 — destroy the weak syllables

dev becomes də-VEL-əp-mənt. estimate (a noun here) becomes ES-tə-mət — the last syllable is *not* "mate", it's mush. probably loses a whole syllable: PROB-ly. the, is, a become thə, əz, ə.

Layer 2 — put the stress where the word says

də-VEL-əp-mənt, not de-ve-lop-MENT. ES-tə-mət, not es-ti-MATE. op-tə-MIS-tic — this one French gets right for free.

Layer 3 — pick one word that carries the point

One chunk gets **one** main emphasis. Everything after it goes flat and low. The point here is *optimistic*:

I think the deVELOpment team's ESTəmət is PROBly a bit op-tə-MIS-tic

And if you've already been talking about the estimate, it drops out entirely — because **English deletes the emphasis on anything already mentioned**:

I think it's PROBly a bit op-tə-MIS-tic

Layer 4 — choose a tune

↘ op-tə-MIS-tic — flat statement. Reads as blunt: *your estimate is wrong*.

↘↗ op-tə-MIS-tic — the fall drops on **MIS**, then floats back up across -tic. Reads as: *I have a reservation here, and I'm leaving you room*. This is how English disagrees politely.

Same words. Completely different meaning.

That's the whole system. Reduce → stress → emphasize → tune. Everything in Part 2 is one of those four layers, plus the ear work that has to come first.

PART 2 — THE PROGRESSION

Five stages, in order. Each one has a **gate** — a test you can run yourself. Don't move on until you pass it. Skipping ahead is the main way people waste a year.

Rough sizes: Stage 0 is two weeks front-loaded then permanent background. Stage 1 is the biggest. Stages 3 and 4 are where the professional payoff sits.

STAGE 0 — Get your ear working

Two weeks of focus, then 5 minutes a day forever.

Why this is first

Every drill in the world says “compare yourself to a native model.” That instruction is useless if you can't hear the difference — and there's a well-documented finding that French speakers specifically struggle to *store* stress information, even when they can hear it in the moment. Metalinguistic knowledge doesn't fix it. Training does.

If you skip this stage, here's what happens: you practise diligently for six months against a standard you can't perceive, and you consolidate your errors. That's the most common way this project fails.

What you do

Build a scored listening quiz. Not casual listening — a test with a number at the end.

1. Take **60 words** you're unsure about. Start with your work vocabulary.
2. For each, get **3–4 different voices** saying it. Forvo gives you multiple native recordings per word. YouGlish gives you the word inside real sentences from hundreds of speakers. Two different text-to-speech voices pad the set.
3. Shuffle **words and voices** together, so you can't learn one speaker's habits.
4. For each clip, answer one question: **which syllable is stressed?** Or simpler: *first syllable — yes or no?*
5. **Check immediately after each item.** This is the part that makes it work, and the part everyone skips.
6. **Write your score down.** Every session.

15–20 minutes, most days. Any flashcard app with audio support does this — audio on the front, stress pattern on the back.

Then add a second quiz: **full vowel or schwa?** Play a word, judge only whether syllable 2 is a real vowel or mush. This is the cue Americans actually use to locate stress, so train it directly.

Make it easier at the start. Take a recording, stretch the stressed vowel in Audacity until the difference is absurd, and train on that. Reduce the exaggeration as your score climbs. This exact design — exaggerate, then fade — is what produced measurable improvement in trained French speakers.

The gate

85% or better on the 60-word quiz, with shuffled voices, two sessions in a row.

Until then, everything else is guesswork.

STAGE 1 — Make weak syllables genuinely weak

The largest single gain available to you. Expect to live here for a while.

First: four things you physically need

You can't reduce a syllable if you don't have the equipment to reduce *into*. About five hours total, once, then done.

A real schwa. Your instinct is the French vowel in *deux* or *peur*. Wrong: that's rounded, front, too long, too clear — and it reads to an American as a *full* vowel, which means it reads as a new word.

- Find it: say “uh” like a shrug. Lips completely relaxed, slightly parted, tongue doing nothing.
- **Check yourself:** say *about, support, problem, common, famous, again, banana* into a mirror. If your lips move forward on the weak syllables, it's wrong. This is a check you can run alone, today, and it's reliable.

The American -er. Enormous numbers of weak syllables end in it: *better, water, after, member, customer, manager, computer*.

- Find it: say “uh”, then — without moving lips or jaw — pull your whole tongue backward and slightly up until the sound darkens.
- No French /ʁ/. Zero scrape, zero friction. A weak syllable containing a scraping consonant is not weak.

Syllabic consonants. The vowel vanishes entirely and the consonant becomes the syllable: *button* = BUT-n. *bottle* = BAH-dl. Also *sudden, written, little, middle, total, certain, often*.

- Find it: say *button* and **never open your mouth after the T**. Go straight from the tongue closure into a nasal hum. If you say BUT-ən, you've turned a two-syllable word into three beats.

Unreleased final consonants. Say stop and freeze with your lips shut. Don't open them.

- French releases final consonants with a little trailing -ə: *stopə, I wantə*. That extra vowel lands exactly where English wants a clean ending, and it's one of the most rhythmically destructive habits available.

Then: the actual work

The build-outward drill. Never read a word left to right giving each syllable its due. Start from the beat and add mush:

TAH → TAH-grəf → fə-TAH-grə-fi

Say the stressed syllable loud and long. Then add the weak ones as fast and quiet as physically possible, without letting them stretch.

The metronome fit. 90 bpm. Tap only the strong beats. Now say these three sentences so each takes **the same total time**:

DOGS EAT BONES.

The DOGS will EAT the BONES.

The dogs would have EATen all of the BONES.

Three beats each. Three syllables versus twelve. If the third takes noticeably longer, you're not compressing. If it sounds choppy, you're inserting pauses instead of squeezing.

The rubber band. Stretch it on strong syllables, release on weak ones. Sounds silly; it's the best tool for making duration something you can feel rather than something you're told about.

Exaggerate to 300%. That's the MAAAAIN PR0000Blem. Swallow the weak syllables until they nearly disappear.

Then **verify the calibration error, once**: record yourself doing what feels like a ridiculous parody of an American. Play it back. It will sound like a mild, pleasant American accent. Almost every learner discovers this, and it permanently changes how hard they're willing to push.

The gate

Two tests, both self-administered:

1. Record yourself saying *administration*. Open it in Praat (or any audio editor), measure your longest syllable and your shortest. **The ratio should be at least 3:1.** Americans run 3:1 to 5:1. If you're at 1.5:1, you haven't started yet.
2. The three DOGS EAT BONES sentences, at 90 bpm, same duration, recorded and checked.

STAGE 2 — Fix the stress on your own vocabulary

The fastest large gain. It's knowledge, not motor skill, so it moves in weeks.

Do this stage for morale as much as anything — it's the one where you'll notice progress fastest.

Build your error map first

Don't work from a generic list. Build your own:

1. Record yourself reading a page of your actual work writing — an email, slide notes, a spec.
2. Check every word of three or more syllables against a US dictionary with audio.
3. Every miss goes in a running list in your notes app. Correct stress marked in CAPS.
4. Review the list weekly.

That list is worth more than every table in Part 3.

Learn four rules, then stop

Most English stress isn't predictable. But four patterns cover an enormous amount of professional vocabulary:

The -ion rule. Any ending with i or u plus vowels — -ion, -ial, -ious, -ual, -ian, -ience — puts the stress on the syllable **immediately before it**. adminiSTRation · deCIision · esSEntial · poliTiCian One rule. Several thousand words.

-ic and -ity: same thing, stress right before. ecoNOMic · aBILity · seCURity

-ate verbs, -logy, -graphy: stress **two** syllables before. CALculate · phoTOgraphy · psyCHOLogy

-ary, -ory, -ery: stress hard left, then reduce everything after. NEcəseri · SEKrəteri · TEMPəreri · LABrətori. This family is a concentrated minefield for you — every French equivalent is late-stressed.

The one heuristic that matters

If an English word looks French and you don't know the stress: guess earlier than feels natural.

The French pull is always to the right. You'll be right far more often than not.

Learn in families

Isolated words don't build intuition. Families do, because they make the *shift* feel normal:

PHOtograph → phoTOGrapher → photoGRAPHic → phoTOGraphy
eCONomy → ecoNOMic → eCONomist
POLitics → poLITical → poliTiCian
Administer → adminiSTRation → adMINistrator

Say all members in a row, tapping the beat.

Two ten-minute items with absurd payoff

Teens vs tens. thir-TEEN (stress at the end, crisp T) versus THIR-dy (stress at the front, and the T becomes a D). If you say *thirty* with a clean T and even stress, it gets heard as *thirteen* about half the time. If you handle numbers professionally, drill this pair set to automaticity.

Initialisms take stress on the LAST letter. C-E-\0 · A-P-\I · K-P-\I · H-\R · U-S-\A. French speakers stress the first or spread it evenly. These are short and carry a lot of load, so errors here are unusually disruptive.

The gate

Dictate a paragraph of your own work writing to your phone's speech recognition.

It should transcribe your polysyllabic words correctly. Systematic misfires point straight at systematic stress errors — free, unbiased, no coach needed.

And: a full week goes by without a new entry on your error list from your core vocabulary.

STAGE 3 — Put the emphasis where you mean it

This is where “understood” becomes “understood correctly.”

One chunk, one emphasis

Break your speech into chunks of roughly 2–7 words. Each chunk gets **exactly one** main emphasis — never zero, never two.

Default position: the **last important content word** in the chunk.

I'm going to the ↘OFFice.

We need to finish this by ↘FRIday.

Everything after it goes flat and dead. This is the part French speakers find hardest, because your instinct is to hold the voice up until the last syllable and then drop.

It's about the ↘MANagement. ← the fall lands on MAN. Three flat syllables after.

I talked to the ↘MANager.

That's the ↘DIFFficulty.

It was COMPLETEly ↘UNnecessary.

Drill those five until the tail stays at the floor. **This single drill removes most of the sing-song impression.**

Moving it changes the sentence

↘I didn't say he stole it.	Someone else said it.
I ↘DIDn't say he stole it.	I deny saying it.
I didn't ↘SAY he stole it.	I implied it. I didn't say it.
I didn't say ↘HE stole it.	Someone else stole it.
I didn't say he ↘STOLE it.	He borrowed it.
I didn't say he stole ↘IT.	He stole something else.

Six sentences, one string of words.

In French you'd do this with syntax — *ce n'est pas moi qui l'ai dit*, clefts, dislocations. **English does it with pitch and assumes you will too.** So you produce grammatically flawless English in which your actual point is unmarked, and your listener misses it. In a negotiation that's expensive.

It also runs in reverse: you *hear* neutral English where an American heard a specific claim. Your comprehension is affected too, at C1.

Delete the emphasis on old information

Anything already in play loses its accent. This is grammar, not manners, and getting it wrong is one of the most reliably detectable non-native markers.

A: Where's the report?
 B: I ↘LEFT it on your desk. ✓
 B: I left the rePORT on your ↘DESK. ✗ ("report" is already known)

A: Do you like Boston?
 B: I ↘LOVE Boston. ✓
 B: I love ↘BOSTon. ✗ (sounds like you're comparing cities)

A: Who broke the window?
 B: ↘PEter broke it. ✓
 B: Peter broke the ↘WInDow. ✗

Clean rule: **already known** → **no emphasis**.

The edge case that breaks French speakers

You'll cope in most positions and then collapse in two specific ones: **at the end of a non-final clause**, and **at the end of a rising question**. There, the boundary wins and the word stress vanishes — comPUTer comes out as compuTER.

The com↘PUTer | was the problem.
 Did you check the com↗PUTer?
 Is it im↗PORTant?
 Are you the ↗MANager?

The skill is **separating pitch height from prominence**: rise to the top of your range on a final *unstressed* syllable while the weight stays on an earlier one. In French those always coincide, so this is genuinely new motor learning. Almost nobody teaches it and it's one of the highest-value drills you can do.

The gate

Produce all six placements of *I didn't say he stole it* on demand, and state what each one means.

Then: record a two-turn dialogue, reading both parts. Check whether your answers re-emphasize words that were already in the question. If they do, you're not deaccenting yet.

STAGE 4 — Melody

Six tunes. Six is enough — well-controlled beats twelve half-controlled.

Tune	Feels like	Used for
Fall ↘	done, committed	statements, commands, wh-questions
Low rise ↗	genuine question	yes/no questions
Fall-rise ↘↗	“...but”	hedging, doubt, polite disagreement
Rise-fall ↗↘	strong, impressed	emphasis, contrast
High rise ↗	“I’m not finished”	continuation, storytelling
Flat →	routine, bored	lists, transactions

Two quick wins, do them this week

Wh-questions fall. Where are you ↘GOing? In French they rise. Rising in English means either “sorry, repeat that” or extreme gentleness — so rising on every one makes you sound permanently unsure. Cheap fix, highly noticeable.

Falls must reach the floor. A fall that stops in the middle of your range reads as evasive or unfinished. Americans commit all the way down. Check it in Praat: your final pitch should approach your session minimum.

The one that matters most professionally: the fall-rise

Without it, you have exactly two options — flat assertion or question. So every reservation you have comes out as a flat assertion, and that is precisely why competent non-native professionals get read as blunt, cold, or tactless.

That won't ↘WORK.	→ dismissive, arrogant
I'm not sure that'll ↘WORK.	→ a normal colleague
↘SOME of them agreed.	→ (...not all)
It's ↘POSSible.	→ (...but unlikely)
We could ↘TRY that.	→ (...I have doubts)
As far as ↘I know...	

How to produce it: start in the middle, jump up on the strong syllable, drop, then float back up. Trace the shape with your hand while you say it. It’s a bigger, more athletic movement than French speakers habitually make, and it will feel theatrical. Do it too big for a few weeks — it normalizes.

And know this about enthusiasm

French signals enthusiasm through **word choice**. English signals it through **pitch range**. “That’s great” said with a narrow range means “fine, whatever.” If colleagues seem to think you’re lukewarm about things you’re actually excited about, this is why — and it’s happening in every conversation you have.

About your pitch range

Your French pitch range is probably completely normal. You're **suppressing** it in English because your attention is consumed by words, grammar and sounds.

That's a *load* problem, not a *capacity* problem — much better news, and it changes the fix. A large part of widening your range happens indirectly, by making everything else automatic so there's attention left over.

Measure both. Read a paragraph in French and one in English, and compare the pitch span. If your French span is much wider, you have your answer and your target.

The gate

Say *You're going to Paris* with all six tunes, and state what each one means.

Then identify tunes in a real clip: 4 out of 6 correct.

PART 3 — RUNNING IT

The 30-minute session

Daily beats bulk. 30 minutes a day genuinely outperforms 3.5 hours on Sunday — motor skills consolidate during sleep, so spacing does something massing can't.

- 5 min Stage 0 ear quiz. Scored. Written down.
- 5 min Warm-up drill for your current stage.
- 15 min Current stage: chorus with a model → shadow it → say it alone.
- 5 min Record a 2-minute monologue on a random topic.
Review 30 seconds of it. Check ONE thing.

Six rules that matter more than any exercise

- 1. One thing per session.** You can consciously monitor roughly *one* prosodic dimension at a time. Name it out loud before you start — “today, only vowel reduction” — and let everything else be bad. Trying to watch stress, reduction, emphasis and melody at once means doing all four badly.
- 2. Drill it, then scramble it.** Many repetitions to find the movement. Then **mix it randomly with other things**. People who only drill in blocks are flawless in practice and revert the instant they're in a real conversation. This is the number one reason pronunciation practice fails to transfer.
- 3. Predict before you check.** Record yourself, **write down what you think went wrong**, and only then compare to the model. Judging first is what trains your ear. Checking immediately makes you dependent on the model.
- 4. Exaggerate, then fade — deliberately.** Every support you use — exaggeration, slow speed, written markup, listening right before speaking — has to be planned out of existence. If you never remove it, you've learned a supported skill.

5. Practise at the edge. Comfortable means you've stopped training. Go faster, drop the exaggeration, remove the script, add a distraction.

6. Climb the ladder for every new thing. Correct prosody while imitating is common. Correct prosody in unplanned speech is rare — because in real speech, finding words and planning content eat the attention that prosody needs.

chorus with the audio → shadow it → from memory → read marked-up text
→ read plain text → retell it → prepared monologue
→ 2 min spontaneous, one focus → real conversation

Every new feature starts at the bottom. Work two or three rungs at once — the bottom for what's new, the top for what's consolidating.

Techniques worth knowing

Chorus — speak *at the same time* as a 3–8 second loop, ten times round. Lowest mental effort, best thing for installing rhythm, because the model carries you.

Shadowing — repeat with a half-second lag while the speaker keeps going. This has more research behind it than any other technique, and its effects land specifically on rhythm, stress and intonation rather than on individual sounds. Exactly what you need.

Humming the contour — hum a sentence back with no words at all. The best single melody exercise, because it strips out articulation and leaves only pitch.

Overlearned chunks — take a short phrase you say constantly and drill it 50–100 times across several days until it comes out perfectly with **zero attention**. Then bank it and build another. Get 50–100 of them.

This is unglamorous and it works, for two reasons: these are the things you say most, so the return per minute is enormous; and an automatic chunk costs no attention, which frees your budget for everything else — including your pitch range.

Start with: your name and role · “nice to meet you” · “can you hear me okay?” · “let me share my screen” · “sorry, could you say that again?” · “I’m not sure I follow” · “that’s a good question” · “just to be clear” · “does that make sense?”

Checking yourself without a coach

Your ear is the compromised part, so build checks that don't depend on it:

Check	Tells you
Mirror	lip rounding on schwa — the fastest error to catch
Phone dictation	systematic mis-transcriptions = systematic stress errors. Free, blunt, unbiased.
Metronome fit	whether you're compressing or just pausing
Praat duration ratio	strong-to-weak, in a number. Target 3:1+.
Praat pitch tracks side by side	your recording next to a native's saying the same words. Differences you couldn't <i>hear</i> become impossible to miss. Closest thing to a free coach.
The parody test	record "wild exaggeration," play it back, discover it's merely correct
Blind A/B	send a colleague two unlabelled clips — you now and you three months ago — ask which is clearer

Praat setup, because the default settings produce garbage: pitch floor 60–75 Hz, ceiling 250–300 Hz for a male voice. Getting this wrong is the number one beginner mistake.

Keep dated recordings. Progress is invisible day to day and obvious across months. Listening to a three-month-old recording is the best defence against quitting.

What to ignore

Roughly 70% of your total gain is in Stages 1, 2 and 3. Another 20% is the fall-rise and pitch range. The last 10% costs more than the first 90% combined.

Don't spend time on: vocal fry · compound stress rules (unreliable even for natives) · more than six tunes · phonetic transcription systems · regional American accents · uptalk · perfecting your R and TH — those are *accent* features, not *clarity* features. A French R inside rhythmically native speech is charming. A perfect American R inside evenly-timed speech is not. · any app that gives you a score without showing you a pitch contour.

Actively avoid three things:

- **Slowing down to be clearer.** It backfires. Slowing uniformly stretches your *weak* syllables and flattens the exact contrast clarity depends on. If you must slow down, lengthen the **strong** syllables and the **pauses**, and keep the weak ones just as short.
- **Over-articulating.** Four-syllable comfortable isn't careful English, it's wrong English. Americans don't say it that way even in formal settings.
- **Suppressing your melody** because someone told you you sound sing-song. That trades one problem for a worse one. Don't reduce the movement — **relocate** it.

Your baseline, recorded today

Twenty minutes. You cannot make this retroactively and you will want it in six months.

1. Read this cold, no preparation:

The development team's report was interesting, though not particularly comfortable reading. It's necessary, I think, to separate the temporary problems from the permanent ones. The laboratory results suggested that the equipment was the difficulty, not the management. Thirteen of the thirty complaints we received last February were about exactly that. Could you check the computer? Is it important?

2. Twenty words: *important, development, comfortable, necessary, photography, administration, category, laboratory, employee, determine, image, purchase, separate (adjective), separate (verb), thirteen, thirty, greenhouse, green house, record (noun), record (verb).*
3. Two minutes explaining your job to someone outside your field.
4. One minute on a random news topic, no preparation at all.

Then four numbers: your longest-to-shortest syllable ratio in *administration* · your pitch span in English · **your pitch span reading French** · your speaking rate.

That third number is the one nobody thinks to take and the most useful one on the list.

Repeat the whole thing monthly. Don't listen to the old recordings for three months — then listen to month one and be encouraged.

Timeline

Word stress on your work vocabulary	weeks — start here, for morale
Careful, monitored speech	1–3 months
Spontaneous speech	4–8 months of daily work
How people perceive you	6–18 months

The part that isn't technical

Doing this properly will feel like pretending. A wide American pitch range will feel theatrical, even a bit undignified, to a French sensibility. Many people unconsciously hold back for exactly this reason, and it's the invisible ceiling on a lot of otherwise diligent practice.

Two things help. **Frame it as a role, not a replacement** — you're adding a register, not deleting your French self. Bilinguals routinely have different voices and even different personalities in each language; that's normal, not fake. And **practise as a character first**, privately, deliberately over the top. The physical skills transfer perfectly well, and performance mode carries no self-consciousness.

Your stated target — completely clear, native-like rhythm, still audibly French — is not a compromise. It's the best goal available, and more achievable than passing for American. Aim at it deliberately.

APPENDIX — REFERENCE

Consult, don't read.

A. The French cognate trap

Shared vocabulary, unshared stress. The French pull is always rightward.

English	The pull
im POR tant	impor-TANT
de VE lopment	développe-MENT
IN teresting	intéres-SANT
COMF tərbl (<i>3 syllables</i>)	confor-TABLE
NE səseri · SE krəteri · TEM pəreri	néces-SAIRE · secré-TAIRE · tempo-RAIRE
CA təgori · LAB rətori · TER ətori	caté-GORIE · labora-TOIRE · terri-TOIRE
IM ij · MES ij · VIL ij · CUR ij	i-MAGE · mes-SAGE · vil-LAGE · cou-RAGE
DOC yəmənt · AR gyəmənt · EL mənt	docu-MENT · argu-MENT · élé-MENT
MAN ijmənt · GU vərmənt	manage-MENT · gouverne-MENT
CHAR əktər · AR kətekt · DIF əkəlt	carac-TÈRE · archi-TECTE · diffi-CILE
EK sələnt · EV ədənt · PREZ ədənt	excel-LENT · évi-DENT · prési-DENT
COM pərəbl · PREF ərəbl · ADM ərəbl	compa-RABLE · préfè-RABLE · admi-RABLE
də TER mən · ig ZAM ən · i MAJ ən	détermi-NER · exami-NER · imagi-NER
PUR chəs · SUR fəs · SER vəs · PRAK təs	(<i>2nd syllable is mush, not “-ace”</i>)

Where French serves you well: perCENT, rouTINE, maCHINE, poLICE, hoTEL, uNIQUE, techNIQUE, guaranTEE, engiNEER, JapANESE.

B. Noun/verb pairs

Noun stresses first, verb stresses second.

RECORD/reCORD · PREsent/preSENT · OBject/obJECT · SUBject/subJECT · PROject/proJECT · CONtract/conTRACT · CONflict/conFLICT · INcrease/inCREASE · IMport/imPORT · PERmit/perMIT · PROgress/proGRESS · TRANSfer/transFER · UPdate/upDATE · SUSpect/susPECT

Also: **-ate words**. As a verb the ending is a full “ate”; as a noun or adjective it's mush. SEPəreit (to separate) vs SEPərət (a separate room) · ESTimeit vs ESTimət · GRADjueit vs GRADjuət · DELəgeit vs DELəgət

C. Weak forms

Every common function word has a reduced version used almost all the time. Using strong forms everywhere is one of the loudest accent markers there is.

a → ə · the → thə · and → ən · of → əv or just ə · to → tə · for → fər · from → frəm · at → ət · as → əz · than → thən · that (conjunction) → thət · can → kən · could/should/would → kəd/shəd/wəd · have/has/had → əv/əz/əd · was/were → wəz/wər · you/your → yə/yər · them → əm · her → ər · there's → thərz

Strong forms come back only for contrast (*I said TO him, not FROM him*) or at the end of a phrase (*Who's it FOR?*).

Contractions are obligatory in speech, not informal. I'm, it's, we've, they'll, don't, can't, won't, wouldn't, isn't, that's, there's, let's. A full form where a contraction belongs reads as emphatic or foreign.

And the multi-word ones: going to → gonna · want to → wanna · got to → gotta · have to → hafta · used to → yusta · kind of → kinda · a lot of → əlada · let me → lemme · don't know → dunno · would have → wooda · did you → didja · what do you → wədəyə

Don't drill these as slang. They appear *because* the rhythm produced them. Someone who inserts “gonna” into otherwise stiff, fully-articulated speech sounds strange. Fix the rhythm and they come free.

D. American connected speech

Flapping. T between vowels, when the following syllable is weak, becomes a fast D. water → wader · better → bedder · get it → gedit · a lot of → əlada · not at all → nədədall · party → pardy Arguably the most identifiable American feature — and it's rhythmic in origin. If you're not flapping, one likely diagnosis is that you're not weakening the following syllable enough.

NT reduction. twenty → tweny · interview → innerview · internet → innernet · center → senner · winter → winner

Linking. Consonant to vowel, straight across: pick it up → pi-ki-dup · turn it off → tur-ni-doff · an apple → ə-napple

Glides between vowels, never a glottal stop: go on → gowon · do it → duwit · I am → aiyam · see it → seeyit

Deleted syllables — normal speech, not sloppiness: comfortable (4→3) · chocolate (3→2) · family → famly · probably → probly · different → diffrent · business → bizness · temperature → tempracher · every → evry

E. Where to break a chunk, and where never to

Natural boundaries: after a long subject · around subordinate clauses · around parentheticals · before conjunctions joining clauses · between list items · around direct address.

Never break: between a determiner and its noun · between a preposition and its object · between an auxiliary and its verb · between an adjective and its noun · inside a compound · between a verb and a short object.

Never pause after a preposition, article, or auxiliary. “*We talked about ... the problem*” sounds broken. “*We talked about the problem ... in some detail*” sounds deliberate.

Need thinking time? Lengthen a function word or put a filler at a boundary. Don’t stop dead in the middle of a phrase.

F. How you’re being read

What you produce	How it lands	Produce instead
Flat fall on a disagreement	blunt, arrogant	fall-rise
Flat statement of a problem	uninterested, resigned	high fall, or rise-fall
Fall on every yes/no question	impatient, interrogating	low rise
Narrow range throughout	bored, disengaged	wider movement, higher starts
Flat “thank you” / “hello” / “sorry”	perfunctory, insincere	wide fall or fall-rise
Rise on everything	uncertain, seeking reassurance	vary; fall on your conclusions
Assertion where a hedge was expected	overconfident	fall-rise

G. Troubleshooting

Symptom	Usual cause	Go to
Fine in drills, falls apart in conversation	only blocked practice; never climbed the ladder	Part 3, rules 2 and 6
Can't hear any difference between me and the model	perception ceiling	Stage 0; Praat pitch tracks
People still ask me to repeat things	almost always word stress or emphasis placement — not vowels	Stages 2 and 3
People say I sound cold or aggressive	missing fall-rise; narrow range	Stage 4
I get interrupted constantly	ending non-final chunks too low	Stage 4
I sound robotic / too careful	over-monitoring; no reductions	Stage 1; force contractions
I sound sing-song	melody at chunk edges instead of on stressed syllables	Stage 3, the MANagement drill
Fine slowly, collapses at speed	you're creating contrast with extra time instead of compression	Stage 1 metronome
My range is flat however hard I try	it's load, not capacity	overlearn more chunks
Speaking English exhausts me	over-monitoring	overlearn more chunks; accept more errors
I've stopped improving	practising what's already automatic	raise difficulty